

Kudzu is also given for muscle aches and pains, especially when they are linked with fever or are affecting the neck and upper back. The root may be taken to treat symptoms of headache, dizziness, or numbness caused by high blood pressure. Kudzu also treats diarrhea and dysentery. Kudzu flowers are traditionally taken to treat alcohol intoxication and hangovers, and are thought to increase the rate of clearance of alcohol from the body, aiding recovery from intoxication. Kudzu root, however, is thought to act in a more or less opposite way—it slows the liver's ability to break down (and clear) alcohol from the system. Kudzu root may therefore increase the risks associated with alcohol consumption, and should not be taken as a "hangover cure."

Research Chinese studies indicate that kudzu increases cerebral blood flow in patients with arteriosclerosis, and eases neck pain and stiffness. U.S. research indicates that kudzu may suppress the desire for alcohol.

Related Species The closely related *P. mirifica* and *P. tuberosa* have been investigated for their contraceptive effect.

Pulmonaria officinalis (Boraginaceae) Lungwort

Description Perennial growing to 1 ft (30 cm). Has broad oval basal leaves, smaller upper leaves mottled with white spots, and clusters of pink-purple flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Lungwort is native to Europe and the Caucasus. It flourishes in mountain pastures and in damp sites. The leaves are gathered in late spring.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Lungwort contains allantoin, flavonoids, tannins, mucilage, and saponins. Pyrrolizidine alkaloids occur in the roots, but in negligible quantities in the leaves.



Lungwort's speckled leaves were once considered a sign of its ability to cure lung problems.

History & Folklore According to the medieval Doctrine of Signatures, which held that a plant's appearance pointed to the ailment it treated, lungwort was effective for chest ailments because its leaves were said to resemble lung tissue.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Given its high mucilage content, lungwort is indeed a useful remedy for chest conditions, and it is particularly beneficial in cases of chronic bronchitis. It combines well with herbs such as coltsfoot (*Tussilago farfara*, p. 278) as a treatment for chronic coughs (including whooping cough), and it can be taken for asthma. Lungwort can also be used as a treatment for sore throats and congestion. In the past, lungwort was given for the coughing up of blood arising from tubercular infection. Lungwort leaves are astringent, and have been applied externally to stop bleeding.

Caution Lungwort is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Pulsatilla chinensis (Ranunculaceae) Chinese Anemone, Bai Tou Weng (Chinese)

Description Perennial herb growing to 10 in (25 cm). Has erect downy stems, compound leaves, bell-shaped flowers, and feathery seedheads.

Habitat & Cultivation Chinese anemone is native to eastern Asia, and is found in Mongolia, China, and Japan. The root is unearthed either before the plant comes into flower in spring, or in autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Chinese anemone contains lactones (including protoanemonin and anemonin), pulsatoside, and anemonol.

History & Folklore Chinese anemone root was first documented in Chinese medicine in the *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (*Shen'ngong Bencaojing*), a herbal written in the 1st century CE.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Chinese anemone is thought to clear toxicity and to lower fever. It is most commonly taken as a decoction to counter infection within the gastrointestinal tract. The root is also used to treat malarial fever and vaginal infections.

Research Chinese studies have shown the root to be potentially valuable as a treatment for amoebic dysentery.

Related Species See pasque flower (*Anemone pulsatilla*, p. 168).

Caution Take Chinese anemone only under professional supervision.

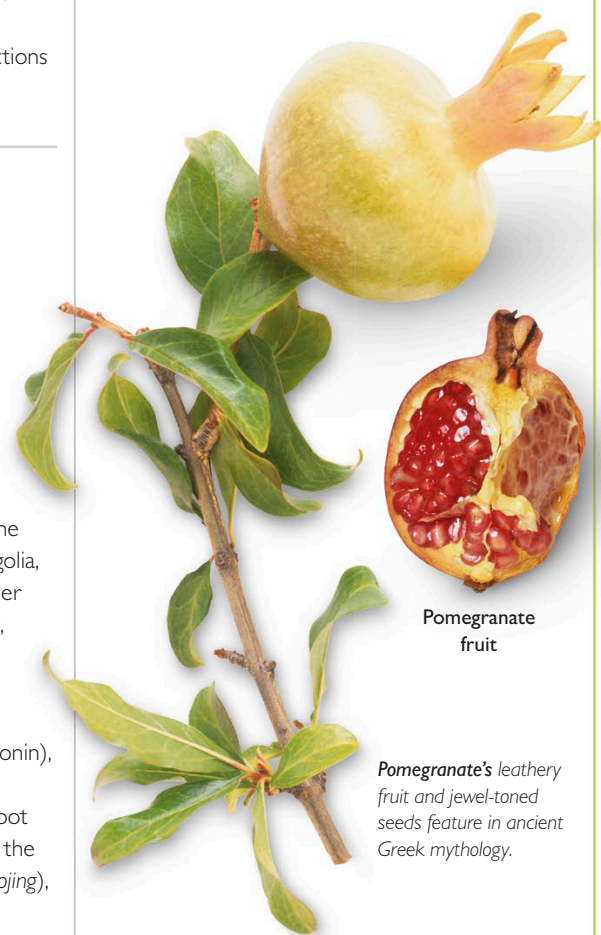
Punica granatum (Lythraceae) Pomegranate

Description Deciduous shrub or tree growing to 20 ft (6 m). Has branches tipped with spines, whorls of lance-shaped leaves, scarlet flowers, and leathery-rinded round fruit containing many pulp-covered seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to southwestern Asia, pomegranate has become naturalized in Europe. The tree is widely cultivated for its fruit, which is gathered in autumn when it is ripe. The bark is also gathered in autumn.

Parts Used Juice, fruit pulp, rind, bark.

Constituents The fruit and juice contain pelletierene alkaloids, ellagitannins (up to 25%), and triterpenoids. The alkaloids are highly toxic.



Pomegranate's leathery fruit and jewel-toned seeds feature in ancient Greek mythology.

History & Folklore In 1500 BCE, the pharaoh Tuthmosis reputedly brought back pomegranate to Egypt from Asia. Prized as a fruit, it was also sought after as a remedy for worms. The Greek physician Dioscorides, in the 1st century CE, knew of the herb's ability to expel worms, but this attribute was subsequently forgotten in Europe for nearly 1,800 years. In the early 19th century, after an Indian herbalist used pomegranate to cure an Englishman of tapeworms, English doctors in India became interested in pomegranate and its medicinal properties were investigated.